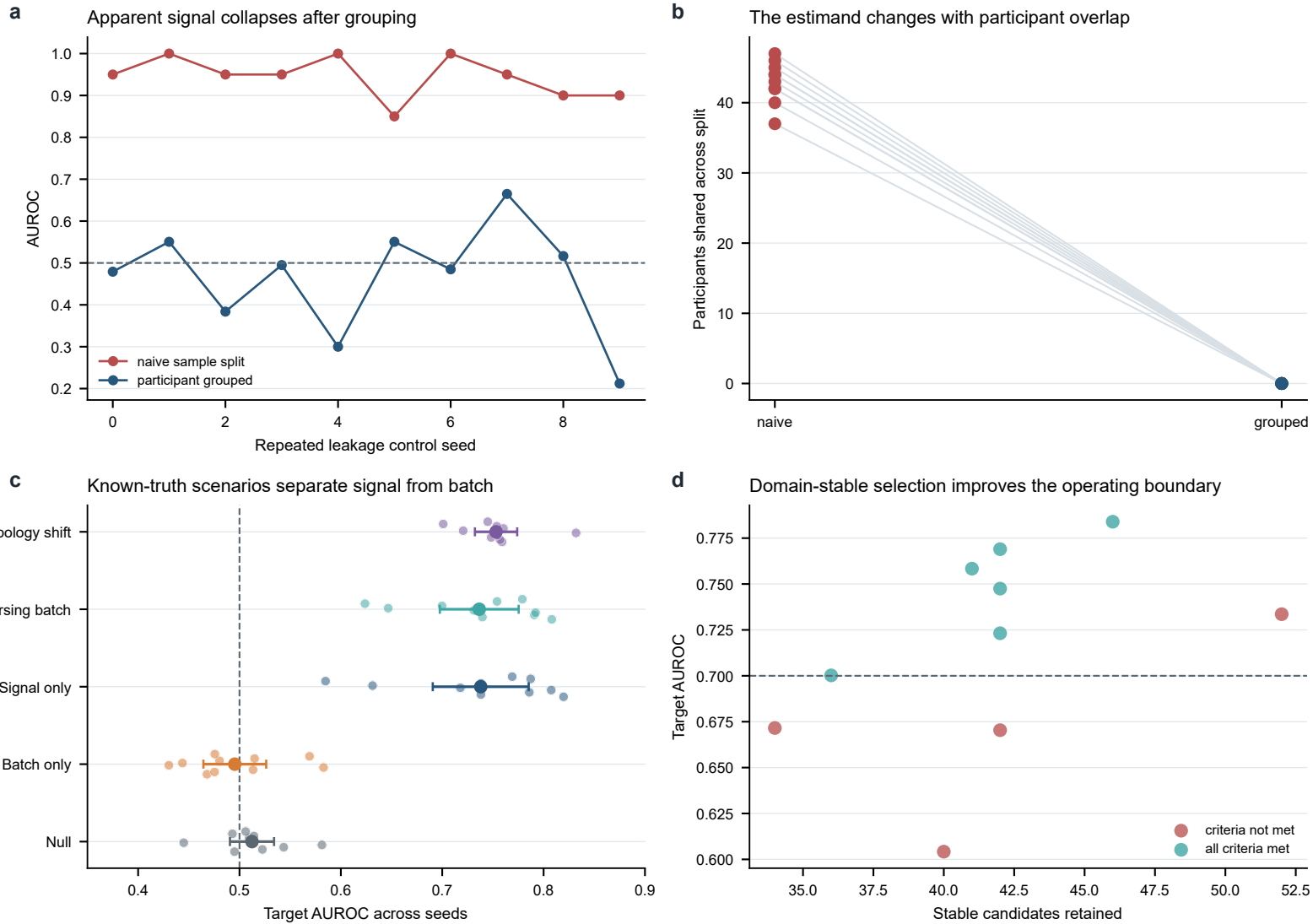Participant structure and known-truth controls expose the dominant failure modes